Editorial: The Passionate Embrace—Consumer Response To Sponsorship

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The rise of commercial sponsorship as a major option in marketing communication is recent, spectacular, and pervasive, being largely a phenomenon of the final decades of the twentieth century. The figures for sponsorship growth across this period indicate something of the current scale of the activity as well as the steep gradient of its ascent to prominence. The worldwide sponsorship market was valued at $2 billion in 1984 and it grew to $23.16 billion by 1999 (Sponsorship Research International, 2000). The United States (with 31.0% of total world sponsorship spending) and Europe (with 35.9% of world total sponsorship spending) represent the largest regional contributors to world sponsorship spending. In these markets, growth continues apace (Sponsorship Research International, 2000).

Although Europe and North America dominate, the sponsorship phenomenon is nevertheless truly global, and in 1999, sponsorship in Asia and the Americas represented 6.0 and 6.1% of total advertising expenditure in these regions, respectively. In Europe, sponsorship as a percentage of total advertising spending was 8.9%, and in the Australia/New Zealand Pacific region, it accounted for 10% of such spending. Although the monetary spending for Africa and the Middle East can be counted in hundreds of millions rather than in billions of dollars, sponsorship expenditure is also a notable component of total advertising spending in these regions (7.3 and 5.6%, respectively).

Corporate commitment to sponsorship is evident from a comparison of spending in the major areas of marketing communications. In the United States, advertising and sales promotion grew by factors of

4–9% per year in the 1990s, but sponsorship grew by double-digit figures in almost all years of the decade and regularly achieved year-to-year growth of 15% (International Event Group, 2000).

Growth in sponsorship expenditure has been driven by a range of factors, including corporate skepticism about the effectiveness of traditional communication in a cluttered media environment, changes in broadcast and other communication technologies, proliferation of media and media vehicles, and the competitive struggle of major brands in mature markets. The commercialization of sports, the arts, and other activities capable of delivering audience numbers has increasingly provided opportunities for sponsors. In turn, the availability of sponsors' monies has encouraged a more commercial orientation at all levels in the organizations responsible for such activities.

It may well be the case that sponsorship has now begun to move through the final increments of rapid growth in an early development curve and increasingly, sponsors, commentators, and academic researchers are raising questions about the value delivered by sponsorship and the effectiveness of the medium in terms of achieving communication objectives. The scale of spending and the pace of development point to the importance of this medium, but increasingly managers and scholars alike are being confronted with the question of how much we actually know about how sponsorship works. This question represents the central focus of this Special Issue.

An inventory of research into sponsorship to date suggests that almost all of the published work is devoted to just two relatively narrow strands of enquiry, namely, the profiling of management practices and the examination of sponsorship as a communication option through the implementation of recall and recognition studies (Meenaghan, 1999). Studies profiling management practices through an examination of the behavior and motivations of sponsorship decision makers have, at this point in time, been replicated in all major sponsorship markets with a consistent and repetitive use of a limited range of methodological approaches and tools. There has been a similar relentless reiteration of recognition and recall studies. It has been recognized for some time now that sponsor awareness and association tests are merely first-line measures of sponsorship impact and of themselves that do not promote a real understanding of the nature of the consumer engagement with sponsorship. Image effects and image transfer are much cited as key sponsorship objectives, but these issues have received considerably less research attention than have awareness effects, perhaps not least because of their less tractable and more problematic nature. It is increasingly evident that studies focusing on the two narrow strands of enquiry indicated above, at best add marginal value to the stock of knowledge and can only provide a diminishing return in terms of enlarging our understanding of the activity. What is clearly lacking is the kind of work that might underpin a comprehensive and unified theoretical framework that would seek to explain how sponsorship actually works.

The scope and scale of research activity in sponsorship is in marked contrast to the range and ambition of studies in advertising. This is not surprising, given that advertising is much older in historical terms and today it remains a much more important medium, both in monetary value and societal impact terms. It has been a consistent focus of scholarly endeavor in a range of behavioral sciences throughout much of the second half of the twentieth century. The relative longevity of advertising as an economic and social phenomenon, the scale and ubiquity of its presence, and the complex issue of its societal impact have engaged the attentions of marketing managers and theorists and have been scrutinized by researchers from a wide range of disciplinary perspectives. What has emerged from this ongoing inquiry is a continuing development in understanding of how advertising works (McDonald, 1992; Vakratsas & Ambler, 1999). The early models of advertising effects in the 1920s (Starch, 1925; Strong, 1925) were followed by the sequential models of the late 1950s/early 1960s (Colley, 1961; Lavidge & Steiner, 1961) leading ultimately to more behaviorally based models (Engel, Kollatt, & Blackwell, 1978; Howard & Sheth, 1969; Joyce, 1967, 1991; Krugman, 1965, McGuire, 1968, 1976; Nicosia, 1966). In more recent years, there has been an emphasis on multiple-effects models, for example, the FCB (Vaughan, 1980), central/peripheral processing (Petty, Cacioppo, & Schuman, 1983), symbolic/functional (Lannon & Cooper, 1984), informational/transformational (Puto & Wells, 1984), and value-expressive/utilitarian (Johar & Sirgy, 1991) models. Current preoccupations include persuasion-based models (Friestad & Wright, 1994) and meaning transfer models (Dyer, 1982; Lannon, 1994; Leiss, Kline, & Jhally, 1986; McCracken, 1987).

Cumulatively these scholarly perspectives have taught us much about the processes by which how advertising works in terms of effects on consumers. By way of contrast with advertising, sponsorship remains underresearched and underconceptualized, and our understanding of consumer response to sponsorship is still grossly inadequate, comparing most unfavorably to the current understanding of consumer response to conventional media advertising. Research into the consumer response to sponsorship is not only much sparser but it has ". . . focused on individual elements of explanation, rather than on the provision of a generalised model which might facilitate overall understanding of the phenomenon" (Meenaghan, 2001).

There is little doubt that this difference in insight is strongly correlated to the wide disparity in the cumulative research activity with respect to each of these areas. The present volume brings together five studies, which, though diverse in orientation, exhibit a common ambition to move beyond the confines of hackneyed recognition and recall studies and the now well-nigh exhausted concern with profiling of management practice. The studies presented here recognize that sponsorship works differently in relation to the consumer, compared to other forms of marketing communication, and that it has the potential to engage the consumer in a very special way. The title of a recent conference (Hollis Directories, 1998) "The Passionate Embrace—Stimulating Consumer Emotions through Sponsorship" captures the essence of the emotional dimension embodied in the sponsor–activity–fan relationship. The articles brought together in this Special Issue share a common concern with elucidating the problems of consumer response, and collectively they provide a fresh body of insight into consumer engagement with sponsorship and the mediating effects of involvement on that response.

Tony Meenaghan proposes a framework for understanding the effects of commercial sponsorship on consumers and provides a detailed examination of key tenets (goodwill, image, involvement, and consumer response) that are widely deployed in the current sponsorship literature. In interrogating each of these constructs, he maps the genesis of each group of ideas, identifies their contribution to our current understanding of how sponsorship works, and seeks to enhance their utility by qualifying the original idea in a sponsorship context (e.g., the concept of *contingent goodwill* is derived through a rigorous examination of the traditional concept of goodwill). Having placed and reinvigorated each of these tenets in the context of sponsorship theory and practice, he proposes their deployment in a model that might provide a basis for understanding the effects of sponsorship on consumers. The model suggests that consumer response to sponsorship is fundamentally driven by the consumer's degree of involvement with, and knowledge about, the sponsored activity and the related extent of goodwill directed toward the sponsor. It is noteworthy that a number of the tenets considered in this article also emerge as key constructs in each of the other articles contained in this Special Issue.

Michel Tuan Pham and Gita Venkataramani Johar revisit the phenomenon of market-prominence bias in sponsor identification, providing additional empirical evidence for the phenomenon and contributing a valuable examination of the underlying processes. They argue that an important cause of widespread sponsor misidentifications lies in the psychology of sponsor identification. Grounded in the recognition that consumers are more likely to attribute credit for sponsorship to brands that they perceive to be more prominent in the marketplace, the controlled laboratory experiment detailed in the study, replicates the phenomenon and shows that the bias arises only when consumers are unable to retrieve the name of the sponsor directly from memory. If direct retrieval is the default process of sponsor identification, it follows that the prominence bias is therefore more likely to occur in cluttered media environments where the sponsor–event associations are more difficult to learn. The authors further demonstrate that during sponsor identification the prominence of the brand is used as a confirmation cue which either validates or conflicts with people's vague recollections. Prominent brands identified or misidentified do, in fact, benefit from enhanced brand image.

In conclusion, the authors note that studies that examine the effects of sponsorship have tended "to invoke different theoretical frameworks" (e.g., information processing, associative and implicit memory, media-vehicle effects, and brand equity). They observe that it is "disconcerting that we know so little about its (i.e., sponsorship's) effectiveness" and argue for additional empirical studies and greater theoretical integration on the part of scholars.

Robert Madrigal details a research study that tests a beliefs–attitude–intentions hierarchy on the part of consumers in the context of a specific corporate sponsorship of a sports team. The consumer's emotional connection to the team is conceptualized in terms of social identity theory, which focuses on that dimension of an individual's self-concept that derives from category or group membership. The study examines the influence of consumers' belief about sponsorship, the perceived importance of those beliefs and identification with the sponsee (i.e., team) on the consumer's attitude toward purchasing a sponsor's products. The impact of attitude on intention to purchase is then tested and the multiplicative effect of sponsee identification and attitude on purchase intentions is investigated.

As well as generating insights into the consumer beliefs–attitude–intention hierarchy the study provides a detailed examination of how such findings can be used to enhance the management of sponsorship. The author offers guidelines for sponsorship selection that go beyond objectives of mere exposure to seek a fit between "the property's core audience and the company's customer base." He cautions that companies that align themselves with properties for which their consumers have no real passion will ultimately have little or no leverage. Favorable beliefs about the benefits accruing to the property from the sponsor are positively related to an attitude toward buying products from that sponsor, and beliefs were found to have an unmediated direct effect on purchase intentions. Therefore, sponsors have an opportunity to influence consumers' beliefs by educating them (through an integrated corporate communication strategy) as to how the association between a brand and a sponsorship property should be interpreted. The findings of the study emphasize the importance of fan identification [with a team] to corporate sponsors.

Thierry Lardinoit and Christian Derbaix constructed a large-scale empirical investigation to examine the impact of field and television sponsorship (individually and in combination) on viewers of televised sports programs. Their research design measures the respective impacts on both recognition and recall dimensions of exposure to field sponsorship stimuli (i.e., sponsors' billboards carrying messages limited to the brand name or to a few words summarizing the brand's positioning platform), to television sponsorship stimuli (opening and closing credits on a sports program in tops-and-tails format), and to a combination of both kinds of stimuli. In particular, the effect of enduring involvement (". . . genuine enthusiasm, a strong and solid interest that comes from the relevance of an object or subject for the individual") on the efficiency of both modalities of sponsorship is examined.

The research succeeds in isolating and measuring the impact on memory of the two modalities individually and in combination, against the background of the level of enduring involvement of the viewer with the sport. In a range of significant findings, the authors suggest that sponsorship seems to emerge as a highly effective communication option for brands seeking to improve unaided recall. Television sponsorship remains the cornerstone of communication through sponsorship, for both recognition and unaided recall objectives.

In the concluding paper, Tony Meenaghan provides a framework for further discussion through a detailed comparison of consumer perceptions toward sponsorship and advertising. He maps the development of research into public attitudes to advertising and highlights the ambivalence toward advertising that informs consumers' love/hate relationship with it. Noting the paucity of similar studies in the sponsorship area, he examines the consumer image of sponsorship at three different levels of aggregation, namely, generic (sponsorship); sponsorship category; and individual sponsored activity, corresponding broadly to the levels of aggregation of generic (advertising), media, and media-vehicle levels in the discussion of advertising. He details the findings of a qualitative research study to elucidate a range of issues that contribute to the understanding of sponsorship image.

The results of this research provide a body of insight into consumer perceptions of commercial sponsorship as a method of marketing communications; the comparative perceptions of consumers toward advertising and sponsorship; and the mediation of such image effects through the phenomenon of involvement. The results show high levels of favorable attitude on the part of consumers toward sponsorship as an activity, though these positive attitudes can be tempered by certain negative factors. Sponsorship benefits from high levels of goodwill and relatively low levels of defense activation as compared to advertising. In providing a range of insights into consumer perceptions of sponsorship, this article offers a useful advance on the path toward a larger understanding of how sponsorship works.

All of the authors are conscious that they are contributing to the framing, rather than the finalizing of a debate, and all provide valuable pointers toward the direction and shape of the future research agenda for sponsorship studies. Collectively these articles represent an important advance in sponsorship studies through their common and emphatic insistence on seeking a better understanding of consumer response to sponsorship. The authors share a conviction that a richer understanding of how sponsorship works can be best achieved through an unwavering focus on the engagement and involvement of consumers with, and the response of such consumers to, sponsorship phenomena. These articles seek to collectively move the quest toward understanding an important stage further.

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